Religious Courtship

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Being Historical Discourses on the Necessity of Marrying Religious Husbands and Wives Only as also of Husbands and Wives being of the same opinions of religion with one another

Daniel Defoe

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Religious Courtship; or, Being Historical Discourses on the Necessity of Marrying Religious Husbands and Wives Only as also of Husbands and Wives being of the same opinions of religion with one another
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The Author's Preface

As this way of writing in cases not much unlike this, has been approved of, and has met with great success in other hands; it has been an encouragement to this undertaking.

Historical dialogues, it must be confessed, have a very taking elegancy in them, and the story being handed forward in short periods, and quick returns, makes the retaining it in the mind the easier, and the impression the more lasting as well as delightful.

The story represented here is capable of such and so many applications to the cases of young people, whose settlement is always in view, that there will never be a time when the instruction will be useless.

If anybody should object, that too much is put here upon the woman's part, and that a lady cannot be supposed in the midst of her lover's addresses, to take upon her, to demand such an account of himself as is here suggested; that few men will stoop to such an examination; and few women venture the loss of their lovers upon such a subject: let such consider, how small the satisfaction here proposed on the lady's part is, and that no gentleman can think hard a woman should be satisfied, whether he is a Christian or a heathen; a man of religion or an atheist; and indeed, no man of any tolerable share of sense, will address himself to a lady for marriage, but he will take care to anticipate her inquiries of that kind, by showing some concern, for knowing what she is herself.

The universal neglect of this trifle, both in men and women, is what this book is designed to correct, and there needs no greater *satire* upon that part, than the success of the several cases here related: (*viz.*) The happy life of the youngest sister who came into the measures proposed; and the miserable condition of the second sister, who rashly threw herself into the arms of a man of differing

principles from her own, though blessed with all the good-humour in the world.

In these accounts, the very great consequence of being equally yoked, is illustrated; and it appears here how essential a share of religion, and a harmony of principles with religion, are to the felicity of the conjugal life.

To those who do not cast off all concern for themselves; who do not make marrying a mere leap in the dark, and as the first lady expresses it, a rushing like a horse into the battle, these things will be of some moment. As to those that are void of care of these matters, they must go on, and pay for their experience, let them take heed, and buy it as cheap as they can.

If the women seem to be favoured in this story, and have the better part of the staff put into their hands, it is because really the hazard is chiefly on their side, and they are generally the greatest sufferers in the success:[1] but if it were otherwise, yet, if they are treated with more than ordinary regard, the author hopes they will not lay that sin to his charge.

The appendix to this work, speaks for itself: irreligious servants in some respects, are the plague of families, and keep our houses always in disorder. 'Tis a wonderful thing to reflect on, that so scandelous an evil, so easy to be rectified, should have gone on to such a degree as it has in the world; and that masters and mistresses of families, have not long ago for their own ease, and for the satisfaction of one another, come to a general law, for the managing, the punishing, and above all, for the recommending of servants; which if they would do, they would easily, I say, bring them to know themselves, and do their duty; neither of which is the case among servants at this time.

But 'tis all our own faults; we recommend sluts, and thieves, and drones, and saucy, insolent fellows, and wenches: I say, we recommend them one to another, without any concern for our neighbour's safety or peace; in a word, to pay the debt of charity for those creatures, which have abused us, we forget the debt of justice to one another, and betray the confidence which one house-

[1] meaning, the succession, or life following the marriage.

keeper and neighbour owes to another, in one of the most essential articles of their families' quiet.

This is all exposed here; and though this part is very short, being but an accident to the other discourses; yet, I presume to say, it will be as acceptable, and, in its kind, as useful as any of the rest.

This fifth edition of this work, recommends itself upon this express condition, *viz*. That the author has not found occasion to alter anything in the fourth (errors of the press excepted) nor have I found room for any additions, that usual pretense to set off new impressions, and impose upon those who have bought the first; being still fully satisfied, the goodness of the design, and the usefulness of the subject, will make the work acceptable wherever it comes.

Part One

There lived in a village near London, an ancient grave gentleman of a good estate, which he had gained by trade, having been bred a merchant, though of a very good family too; he had been a man in great business, but his circumstances being easy, and his love of a retired life increasing with his years, he had left off his business, and taken a house a mile or two out of town; he was a widower at the time of this affair, his wife having been dead some years before.

He had five or six children, and all grown up, but none settled in the world, though he had an estate sufficient to give them very plentiful fortunes. His three daughters were very agreeable women, and, which was still better, were very sober, modest, sensible and religious young ladies, two of them especially: and as the character of their father, and the fortune he was able to give them, recommended them very well to the world; so they had several gentlemen that made honourable and handsome proposals to their father for their marriage.

I shall most carefully avoid giving any room here so much as to guess what opinion in religion they were bred up in, or whether the old gentleman was a churchman or a dissenter; and the same caution I shall use with all the rest of the persons whom I shall bring upon the stage in the course of this story: my reason for which everybody will understand by the nature of the relation, and of the times we live in.

The father of these ladies had been a man always, till now, hurried in the world; being crowded with a vast business, taken up with getting money, and with growing rich; so that he neither had much concern for, or indeed took any care of, the education or instruction of his children, but left them wholly to the conduct of their mother. Nor was it any great loss to the children, especially

to the daughters, their mother being a most pious, religious, and virtuous lady, who was not only extraordinarily qualified to instruct her children, but gave up her whole time to it from their childhood.

One morning, a little before her death, calling her daughters to her, she told them, among other things, that as to marriage, she had but two injunctions to lay upon them, which, as she was not likely to live to see them settled, she would desire them to lay down as maxims in the choice of their husbands; and which she would, as upon her death-bed, if her words had any extraordinary influence upon them, oblige them to observe strictly, *viz.*

1. Never to marry any man, whatever his person or fortune might be, that did not, at least, profess to be a *religious man*.
2. Never to marry any man, how religious soever he may *seem to be*, if he was not of the same principles and opinion in religion as themselves.

And as this was but a little before her death, so the daughters were more than ordinarily touched with the sense of it, and resolved to pursue it exactly. How they did pursue it, and the consequences of it, will be seen in the following dialogues.

It followed some time after, that a gentleman of a very good estate courted the youngest of these daughters; and making very handsome proposals to her father, (*for he offered to settle 600 l.* per annum *on her*) the father was exceedingly pleased with the match; he being a gentleman thoroughly well bred; and an agreeable person, and, in a word, nothing appearing to give the least reason, why he should not be as acceptable to the lady as he was to the father.

As he came thus recommended to the father, there appeared nothing disagreeable in it to the young lady; nor had she at his first appearance the least exception to make against the gentleman as to his person: Indeed, as to his estate, *though her fortune was very handsome*, yet his was so far beyond it, that there was no comparison in the case; and besides all this, she had this engaging circumstance in the proposal, *viz.* That she being the youngest of the three daughters, the gentleman had passed over her two eldest sisters, and had singled her out by his more particular fancy; giving her that undeniable mark of his affection, *viz.* That she would be

the wife of his choice, and consequently that she would have an uncommon security of the sincerity of his love to her.

The father opposed his proposal a little at first, as a slight offered to his eldest daughters; but the gentleman told him, that he hoped, if he accepted his design of coming into his family, he would give him leave to take the person his judgment had made choice of, and that he thought he might be happy with: that it would be a very hard circumstance to him, and what he could not think of with patience, to marry one of his daughters, and be in love with another: that he was very far from offering any slight to the eldest, letting him know, that happening to see the youngest first, he found such suitableness, and something so agreeable in her to him, that he resolved to look no farther: that perhaps, if he had seen the eldest or the second daughter first, it might have been the same thing; but that as he could not answer for the biass of his fancy, so neither could he answer it to his own conduct, not to choose her, that was from the first moment he saw her, the only woman in the world that he ever thought could make him happy.

Her father could make no return to an answer that had so much weight in it, and which appeared to be so sincere; and therefore not acquainting his eldest daughter with the design he had had to propose her to him, he took occasion to talk to them all together one morning, as they were drinking chocolate; and begins merrily with them thus:

Dialogue One

Father. Well, girls, you little think now, which of you all is like to be first married. What say you, child? [*turning to the youngest*] I hope you are content to let your eldest sisters go before you?

3rd Daughter. Yes, yes, sir; I desire both my sisters may go before me; for I see nothing in the world, to make me in haste.

Fa. Why? what's the matter that you are so out of love with the world all on a sudden? Is it that you think yourself too good for everybody, or everybody too good for you?

3rd Da. No, sir; I am neither so vain to think the first, or so humble to think the last; but I desire to think of myself as I ought to think.

Fa. How is that pray?

3rd Da. Why, sir, I think I live too well to change for the worse, and this is not an age to change for the better; and therefore I desire to be as I am.

Fa. Why is this age so much worse than that that went before, pray?

3rd Da. Nay, sir, I don't know; but I am very well satisfied, sir, with your first proposal, that my sisters may try before me.

Fa. Well, well; and if you go before your sisters, there will be no harm done, if it be to your liking, I hope; I dare say, none of your sisters will be angry: [*at which, the two eldest said, "No, no; we shall be very glad to see it:"*] and so they fell to jesting with their younger sister, till they almost angered her.

"You are mightily difficult," *says the eldest sister*, "that you fall upon the whole world, as if there was nothing good enough for you."

Says the second sister, "She will be easily pleased as another, I warrant her, if she was talked to in earnest;" upon which, notwith-

standing their father was present, they fell to rallying one another, between jest and earnest, a little too warmly, as follows:

3rd Da. That may be; as *my eldest sisters* teach me, I hope they intend to set me a good example; for *it's their turn first*.

1st Da. We don't know that; if a good offer comes in your way, you'll hardly put it off, and say, *Your betters must go before you*.

3rd Da. For all you are both my *eldest sisters*, I question whether you understand what a *good offer* means: and it may be, have considered it *no more than I*; there's a great deal in that word.

1st Da. Oh! I'll explain it in a few words; *a good estate*, and *a man you like*.

2nd Da. Nay; you might have stopt at the first: it's no matter what the man is, if the estate be but good.

3rd Da. Is that the example *my eldest sisters* intend to set me?

Fa. Ay; and a good example too, *child*.

3rd Da. You are disposed to jest, sir; but I believe you would not be pleased with such a way of choosing a husband for any of your daughters.

2nd Da. I hope my father would; *I am sure I should*.

3rd Da. That's no token to me that you have considered much of the matter, *as I said before*.

2nd Da. Why? What would you have besides a good estate? What matter is it what the man is? I would pass by a great many homely defects for a good settlement.

3rd Da. *As for the homely defects*, perhaps I may be no nicer than you, if there was nothing else wanting.

2nd Da. What can be wanting, if there be money enough?

3rd Da. Nothing, I hope, when my sister comes to choose.

2nd Da. *No*; nor when you come to choose neither, it *may be*.

3rd Da. I am afraid there will.

2nd Da. For my part I shall enquire for nothing else, as I know of.

3rd Da. No! What would you have your husband have *no religion*?

2nd Da. What have I to do with his religion? He'll be a *Christian* I hope.

3rd Da. And what if he should not?

2ND DA. Nay, then he may be a heathen *and he will*, what's that to me.

3RD DA. That's a proof of what I said before, that you have not considered much of the matter.

2ND DA. No, indeed, not I; but I suppose my younger sister has.

2ND DA. Your younger sister never told you so yet: But methinks there requires very little consideration, to say, If I ever should marry, I would not have a rake, a heathen, a profligate fellow, a man without religion, purely for his money; if you think these things no objections, and are got over such scruples in the case, I must tell you, sister, that it seems, the business has been more in your head than in mine, or at least to worse purpose.

2ND DA. Well, it may be so; and then it may follow, that when you have considered more of it too, you will be of my mind.

3RD DA. What, to marry an atheist! a man of no principles! that knows neither God nor Devil?

2ND DA. Ay, ay; that, or anything else, if you have but a good settlement, child. A good settlement will make up all those things; you'd take him, I warrant you.

3RD DA. No, sister; nor for all that I can see with my eyes.

2ND DA. Oh, you don't know your own mind, till you come to be tried; we shall see you tell another tale hereafter.

3RD DA. I an't so fond of a husband, whatever my sister is.

Here the father seeing that the younger sister began to be a little moved, and unwilling they should make a quarrel of it, put an end to the discourse, and so they soon after withdrew; and then the father being left with the eldest daughter only, went on with his discourse thus to her.

FA. Child, you are a little too hard upon your sister.

DA. She should not have taken it so, sir; she knows it is all but in jest.

FA. But you do not know, whether it may be all in jest or no.

DA. Nay, sir, I am sure all our share in it was in jest; if there is anything in it, I should have talked after another way.

[*Here she was very inquisitive with her father to know if there was anything in it or not, at which he only smiled.*]

Da. *Nay*, sir, then I understand how 'tis.

Fa. *Well*, *child*; how will you take it, to see your youngest sister married before you?

Da. Oh very well, sir, I shall be very glad of it, if it be for her good: But if I were to speak my mind, I should say something to it about her, that, it may be, there may be occasion for.

Fa. Well, pray speak your mind then.

Da. Why, sir, for all my sister's bantering her, I must own, our youngest sister will not be easily pleased in a husband, as times go now.

Fa. How do you mean, child?

Da. Why, sir, I mean, that though she may be the first of us, that shall be asked, she may be the last of us that will be married.

Fa. *Ay*, *my girl*! Is it so with you then! What have you been both making your bargains without me! And are you so near concluding! That's very hard.

Da. Dear Father, how could you have such a thought of us! you are quite wrong; you don't understand me at all.

Fa. Nay; how can I understand you any other way? If it is not so, explain yourself.

Da. Sir, I mean, that my sister will not be easily pleased; she will scarce take the first that comes, I dare say.

Fa. No; then I shall take it very ill: for I assure you, he that I mean is a very *good one*.

Da. Nay, if he is a *good one*, it may be, she may; but 'tis a question, sir, whether her *good one* and your *good one* may be both of a sort.

Fa. Why he has a very good estate, I'll assure you; far beyond what she can expect.

Da. That's a good thing; but that will go but a little way *with her*, I know.

Fa. Well, he is very handsome, well-accomplished, well-bred gentleman; she cannot mistake him; he is a most agreeable young gentleman, I assure you.

Da. That won't go a bit the farther with her neither, *I am sure*.

Fa. Then he is in love with her, and has singled her out from you all; she will be the wife of his affection to be sure; what can she desire more?

Da. She will desire *something more* still, sir, though the last is the thing will go very far, doubtless; farther than anything we have talked on yet: But *you know*, *sir*, my sister is a very sober, religious body, and she will never marry any man that is not so too; though his estate, his person, his accomplishments were beyond all the rest of the world: and this was the reason, why I said she may be first asked, and last married.

Fa. Nay, I can't tell, how matters are, as to that.

Da. I'll assure you, sir, she will know how it is as to that, before she engages.

Fa. Nay, let her alone to that part, that's none of my business.

[*Here he was touched a little, and reflected back softly to himself; Oh why do I say, 'tis none of my business? Whose business is it, if it is not mine?*]

Da. But, sir, when you know her mind in that case, it may prevent your receiving any disappointment, and prevent her venturing to disoblige you, in refusing what you may propose to her.

Fa. No, no; I dare say she won't refuse him; she is not such a fool neither.

Da. Dear sir, then I hope you know he is a sober, religious gentleman.

Fa. I know nothing to the contrary, my dear; I suppose he is.

Da. But, sir, it makes me anxious about it, because you said just now, you could not tell: I hope you will enquire farther into it before you take any farther steps about it.

Fa. Why, child, as to that, I dare say, she need not be concerned; he is so good a humoured man, he will never cross her in small matters, especially in religious things. Child, do you think any gentleman can be angry, that his wife is sober and religious? To be sure, she may be as religious as she will.

Da. *O dear sir*, my sister can never be satisfied so, sure.

[*He observes his daughter concerned at it, and that tears stood in her eyes.*]

Fa. Child, what's the matter? What makes you so concerned about it?

Da. 'Tis a sad life, sir, for a woman to have no help from her husband in things that are good, but only to have liberty for

herself to be as good as she will, or rather as good as she can: By the same rule she may be as bad as she will; and it may be, he will like ne'er the better for one, nor the worse for t'other.

Fa. Well; he is a fine gentleman, and professes a great affection for her.

Da. Before he has seen her, it may be, or knows anything of her.

Fa. No, no; he has seen her, but he has never been in her company, I know.

Da. So that I find he cares not what she is; he chuses by her outside only.

Fa. He takes all the rest upon trust.

Da. But my sister won't take him so, I can tell him that.

Fa. I shall take it very ill from her if she slights him; for I assure you, he is not to be slighted, he has very near 2000 *l*. a year estate.

Da. But I am sure, if he is not a *religious man*, she will slight him for all that; my meaning is, she will never *have him*; I suppose she will not be rude to him.

Fa. If she *does refuse him*, she and I shall quarrel, I assure you, and that very much.

Da. I hope you won't, sir: You will give her leave to chuse to her own liking; it is for her life, and she must bear the discontent of it; nobody can bear it for her: Besides, sir, you know she was very religiously instructed by my mother.

Fa. Ay, ay; your mother was a good woman.

Da. And you know, sir, *I suppose*, what advice my mother gave her upon her death-bed, *viz. Never to marry a man that was not religious*, *whatever other advantages might offer with him*.

Fa. And did she not give you the same advice too, my dear?

Da. Yes, to be sure, and all of us.

Fa. Well; and yet you heard what your sister said just now, *viz. That she would not trouble herself about it*, *so there was but a good estate*.

Da. But I hope my sister would consider better, if she came to the question.